

Environmental Assessment for the Ivy Mass 2026 Training Exercise at Pinon Canyon Maneuver Site, Fort Carson, CO

April 2026

PURPOSE AND NEED

The purpose of the Proposed Action is to conduct a one-time, brigade-level Combined Arms Live-Fire Exercise (CALFEX) to certify a unit on its core warfighting functions for future deployments. This certification is driven by the need to validate the Army's new, next-generation digital command-and-control (C2) systems. Success requires a training environment that meets three specific criteria that are not available at Fort Carson: (1) a large, unconstrained land area for dispersed maneuver at a scale not achievable at Fort Carson; (2) austere field conditions that force reliance on organic systems away from established infrastructure; and (3) a data-rich operational environment where long-range sensors, such as UAS, can be fully employed. The Piñon Canyon Maneuver Site (PCMS) satisfies the essential requirements for this action and is identified as the reasonable alternative to meet mission requirements. As explained in the analysis of alternatives, other locations such as the National Training Center were eliminated from detailed study because they are doctrinally inappropriate for this specific, intermediate-level certification event.

This temporary action is fundamentally different from the Army's separate proposal to establish a permanent impact area and associated ranges at PCMS, which is intended to support enduring Multi-Domain Operations (MDO) training objectives for future Army formations, among other reasons. The permanent modernization proposal is a long-term infrastructure initiative designed to provide a persistent venue for large-scale maneuver and integrated fires training across multiple domains. In contrast, the proposed Temporary Impact Area supports a single, time-sensitive training event for one brigade, driven by a unique, technology-validation requirement and existing Stryker brigade training doctrine. Training on the Army's next-generation digital command and control (C2) systems needs to be geographically dispersed across a wide area to realistically test the digital network's ability to connect sensors, command posts, and shooters in a combined arms live-fire environment.

We have reviewed this temporary training event to ensure it is a genuinely separate action and not just "Phase One" of the Enhanced Mission Training proposal at PCMS. Ivy Mass Training event is a standalone proposal for four main reasons. First, it has a clear start and finish, ending completely once the training and site cleanup are done in May 2026. Second, this training is useful all on its own; the brigade's certification is a tangible outcome that doesn't depend on whether the permanent impact area is ever built. Third, approving this single training event does not lock the Army into any future decisions, as Army decision-makers retain the full authority to build, modify, or cancel the separate permanent impact area project in the future based on its own separate review. Finally, the funds for this single exercise do not commit the Army to spending any money on other, separate projects; it is a self-contained cost for a self-contained event.

Furthermore, the need is to conduct this validation in an austere setting that simulates expeditionary conditions, forcing the unit to rely entirely on its organic systems away from established infrastructure. The expansive and undeveloped nature of PCMS provides a unique and essential environment to meet these specific training requirements, which are a prerequisite for the unit's certification. The temporary

action has independent utility, does not rely on or enable the permanent impact area proposal, and would not prejudice any future decision regarding long-term modernization at PCMS.

This Environmental Assessment (EA) has been prepared in accordance with the National Environmental Policy Act of 1969 (NEPA)¹, the Department of Defense NEPA Implementing Procedures², Army Guidance on the Department of Defense National Environmental Policy Act Implementation Procedures (Memorandum from Assistant Secretary of the Army for Installation, Energy and Environment dated August 8, 2025) and Command Policy Memorandum- U.S. Army Materiel Command (AMC) Record of Environmental Consideration (REC) and Categorical Exclusion (CATEX) Screening for National Environmental Policy Act (NEPA) Reviews (Memorandum from Headquarters, U.S. Army Materiel Command dated January 30, 2026).

PROPOSED ACTION

The U.S. Army proposes to conduct a single, one-time, brigade-level CALFEX at PCMS. This action would occur within the context of ongoing military operations at PCMS, as analyzed in the 2015 Training and Operations Environmental Impact Statement (EIS), which includes general maneuver training, small arms fire, helicopter support, convoy to and from PCMS and logistical support. The proposed CALFEX would simulate a deliberate engagement against a near-peer adversary. Activities for this specific event will include the movement and operation of wheeled vehicles in designated maneuver corridors and the establishment of temporary firing positions outside the newly designated temporary impact area (TIA). It will also include the construction of trenches for safe observation and as training objectives, and the employment of various types of training ammunition. As detailed below, this assessment conservatively assumes the use of training rounds equipped with low-yield spotting charges (up to 0.5 lbs. TNT equivalent), though some projectiles may be completely inert. For the purpose of this analysis, all training involves the use of live propellant charges and is considered a live-fire event (discussed in detail below). The exercise will unfold across five sequential phases: deploying forces to set conditions, conducting support-by-fire and maneuver, breaching enemy obstacles, seizing the primary objective, and establishing a defense against a counter-attack. There will be several iterations of this sequence as each subordinate unit passes through.

To accomplish this mission, the company will maneuver in Stryker vehicles. Ground-based weapon systems proposed for use include 155mm artillery, 7.62mm, and .50 caliber ammunition with low-impact spotting charges. The unit will also utilize various Unmanned Aerial Systems (UAS) for reconnaissance and targeting.

A key component of this proposal is the use of munitions with low-yield energetic components. As a conservative assumption for analysis, this assessment assumes the potential use of munitions with spotting charges equivalent to up to one-half pound (0.5 lbs.) of TNT per round. In accordance with U.S. Army regulations, specifically TC 25-8 (Training Ranges) and DA PAM 385-63 (Range Safety), a Temporary Impact Area (TIA) will be established. This TIA is composed of one or more surface danger zones (SDZs). An SDZ represents the maximum area on the ground and in the air where a projectile, fragment, or ricochet could land under approved firing conditions, thereby constituting the area required to contain all munitions safely. The map associated with this analysis depicts these overlapping SDZs, which define the area where access will be temporarily restricted to authorized personnel during live-fire periods. All activities will be coordinated with PCMS Range Operations and the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) to deconflict airspace, which will include temporarily raising the restricted airspace

¹ <https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/COMPS-10352/pdf/COMPS-10352.pdf>

² <https://www.denix.osd.mil/nepa/denix-files/sites/55/2025/06/DoD-NEPA-Procedures-FINAL.pdf>

ceiling to at least 18,000 feet above mean sea level (MSL), but possibly as high as 60,000 feet MSL. **This proposal does not include land expansion at PCMS and it is not required.**

Following completion of the event, the TIA will be closed. As required by range safety protocols, a thorough surface clearance will be conducted, including a unexploded ordnance (UXO) clearance sweep by Explosive Ordnance Disposal (EOD) personnel to handle any potential dud TNT safely and remove all projectile debris. Following this clearance, the area, including any constructed trenches, will be returned to its prior operational status by the Land Rehabilitation and Management (LRAM) and Integrated Training Area Management (ITAMs) programs.

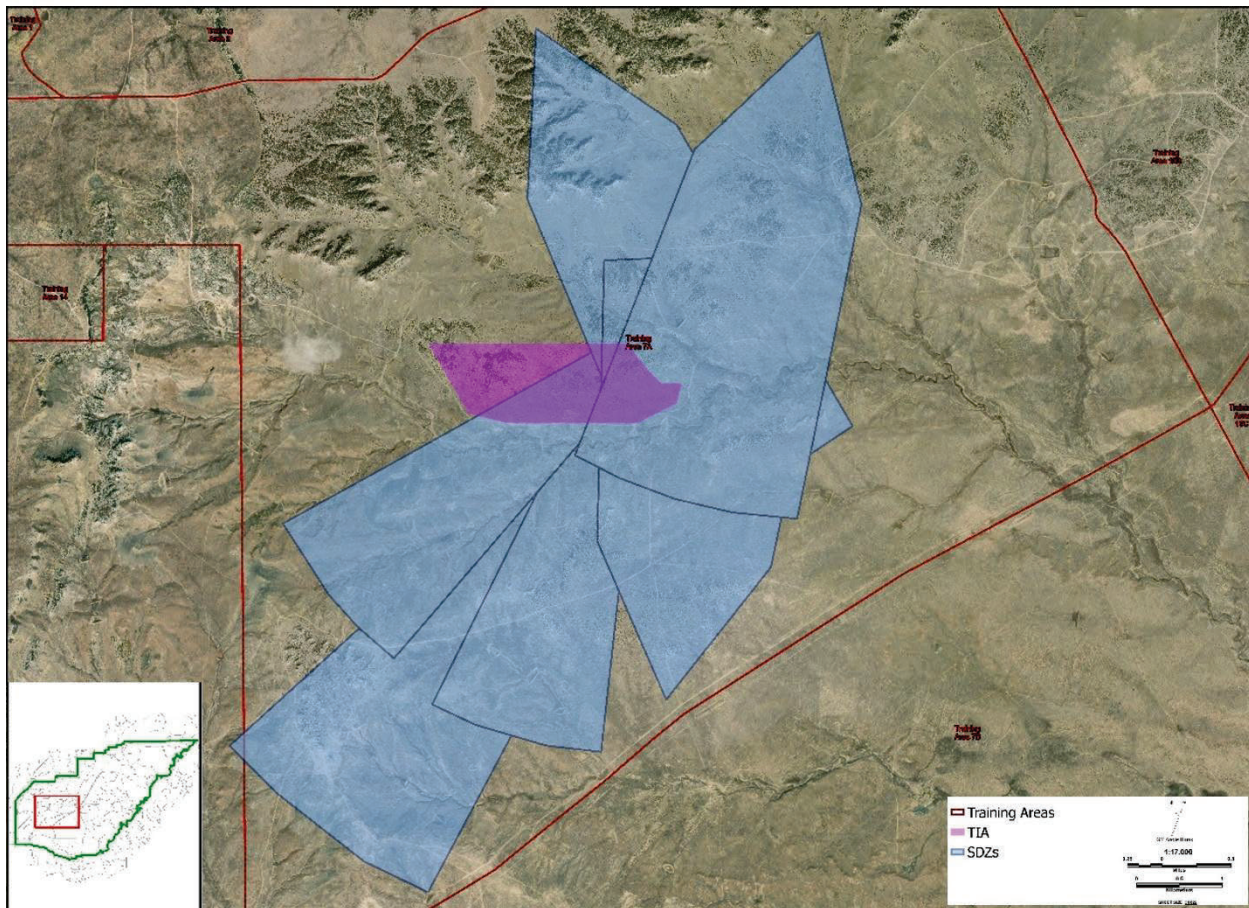


Figure 1: Map of proposed action including the temporary impact area (TIA) and the surface danger zones (SDZ) from the firing points.

NO ACTION

Under the No Action Alternative, the authorization to conduct the live-fire component of the proposed CALFEX at PCMS would be denied.

The unit would still deploy to the PCMS and conduct all training activities currently permitted within the parameters and restrictions established in the 2015 Training and Operations EIS. These baseline activities include the maneuver portions of the training exercise and live-fire training with weapon systems already approved for use at PCMS, such as small arms up to and including .50 caliber. For this specific certification event, the crucial large-caliber indirect fire component (155mm artillery) would have to be simulated.

The unit would still deploy to the PCMS and conduct the maneuver portions of the training exercise to gain as much value as possible. This action would occur within the parameters and restrictions established in the 2015 EIS. However, no live or inert munitions would be fired. The "live-fire" would be simulated.

This course of action would prevent the unit from accomplishing its required, integrated, live-fire certification. This would directly risk the readiness of U.S. forces. Therefore, the No Action Alternative does not meet the fundamental Purpose and Need of the Proposed Action.

While similar certification exercises have been conducted at Fort Carson in past years, the doctrinal and technological shift to the Army's next-generation digital command and control systems renders Fort Carson's ranges insufficient for this specific undertaking. The previous training paradigm did not require the same scale of geographic distribution to validate a unit's warfighting functions. The new digital command and control doctrine requires a large, contiguous land area to realistically employ long-range sensors, connect them to maneuver and fire-support units via the digital network, and execute long-range precision fires. The constrained nature of Fort Carson's ranges does not provide the necessary space to create this distributed "sensor-to-shooter" environment. In contrast, the expansive and open terrain at PCMS is uniquely suited for and essential to training and validating these modern command and control systems to the required standard.

Therefore, under the No Action Alternative, while the unit could still conduct limited small-arms training at PCMS or Fort Carson, it would be unable to conduct the integrated, large-scale CALFEX required to certify its primary digital command and control warfighting systems.

While the No Action Alternative would avoid the temporary, localized training impacts associated with the Proposed Action, it would not meet the Purpose and Need for the Army to certify the brigade as ready for any future deployment or validate the required technology package. For this reason, the No Action Alternative does not satisfy the operational requirements driving the proposed training event but is retained for comparison in the spirit of the NEPA process.

ALTERNATIVES CONSIDERED BUT NOT CARRIED FORWARD FOR FULL ANALYSIS

Training at the National Training Center (NTC) or other Combat Training Centers

In response to public comments on the Draft Environmental Assessment that indicated a misunderstanding of Army training doctrine, the following clarification has been added to the Final EA.

The Army considered whether this training could be conducted at the National Training Center (NTC) at Fort Irwin, California. This alternative was eliminated from detailed analysis because it is not a reasonable or practicable alternative for this specific action.

Army training doctrine follows a progressive and sequential model. Units must first achieve a series of certifications and readiness benchmarks at their home station and at local or regional training areas before they are programmed to attend a national-level training center location. This Ivy Mass training event is designed to fulfill a critical intermediate step in that doctrinal progression, serving as a required certification before the unit can be considered ready for a subsequent NTC rotation.

Therefore, proposing to conduct this specific training at the NTC would be doctrinally inappropriate, akin to sending an athlete to the Olympics before they compete in qualifying events such as a tryout. Because it does not align with established Army training progression, it is not a reasonable alternative and was not carried forward for detailed analysis in this EA.

ENVIRONMENTAL CONSEQUENCES OF PROPOSED ACTION

This analysis is tiered from the 2015 PCMS Programmatic EIS and the 2005 Range 9 EA, both of which evaluated the effects of ongoing training at PCMS. To minimize environmental impacts and ensure the training remains consistent with established stewardship practices at PCMS, the Army would implement a suite of best management practices and mitigation measures drawn from the 2005 Range 9 EA, 2015 EIS for Training and Operations at PCMS, the current INRMP and Integrated Cultural Resources Management Plan (ICRMP), and ongoing ITAM/LRAM programs.

Soil and Vegetation

The project area at Piñon Canyon Maneuver Site (PCMS) is characterized by a semi-arid, shortgrass prairie ecosystem. As described in the 2015 Training and Operations EIS, soils in this region are generally sandy and well-drained, making them susceptible to wind and water erosion where vegetation is sparse. The landscape is dominated by native short grasses, such as blue grama, interspersed with various shrubs, forbs, and cacti. These soil and vegetation resources are actively managed as part of an operational training landscape under the installation's ITAM program, and the native plant communities are adapted to the periodic physical disturbance associated with military training activities.

The Proposed Action would result in short-term, localized impacts to soil and vegetation. These effects are consistent with those analyzed in the 2015 EIS for Training and Operations at PCMS and the 2005 Range 9 EA, which evaluated similar live-fire maneuver activities in the same location. The impacts from these activities that will also occur during this exercise—such as soil compaction and vegetation trampling from the movement of Strykers and other military vehicles—are consistent in nature and intensity with the effects previously analyzed in the 2015 EIS for Training and Operations at PCMS.

Impacts would primarily result from two activities: vehicle maneuver and munitions employment. The movement of wheeled vehicles will cause temporary soil compaction and trampling of vegetation. Munitions effects will vary by type. As determined in the formal effects analysis, impacts from 155mm artillery with spotting charges may include shallow cratering, localized soil displacement, and potential scorching or burning of surface vegetation at the point of impact. Impacts from 7.62mm and .50 caliber ammunition are limited to minor surface scarring and are not expected to cause significant ground disturbance.

Soil protection measures would include using existing roads, military supply routes, and maneuver corridors to avoid unnecessary disturbance, as well as avoiding areas known to have highly erodible or unstable soils. Maneuver would be limited during periods when soils are saturated or otherwise vulnerable to rutting. Following completion of the exercise and required UXO surface clearance, the Army would conduct LRAM rehabilitation to restore soil structure, relieve compaction, stabilize disturbed surfaces, and reseed with native vegetation as appropriate. These actions ensure that soil impacts remain temporary and reversible.

Vegetation impacts would be minimized by routing maneuver along existing open areas and avoiding unnecessary off-route travel. Natural Resources staff would advise on seasonal considerations such as wildfire risk, nesting periods, or seed-set timing to avoid sensitive windows. Post-exercise LRAM activities would promote the reestablishment of native vegetation and include monitoring for invasive species, which would be treated promptly if detected. These measures, consistent with the INRMP, ensure that vegetation communities remain resilient and that no long-term loss of plant cover occurs.

Because the TIA would be used once for this finite training event, these impacts would be temporary and reversible. Following completion of the exercise and required UXO surface clearance, the Army will implement LRAM actions under the ITAM program. These actions include repairing rutting, alleviating

compaction, stabilizing disturbed surfaces, and reseeding as appropriate to prevent erosion and control invasive species. With these established restoration measures in place, the Proposed Action is not expected to cause significant impacts to soil or vegetation resources.

Surface Water Features (Arroyos, Playas, Creeks)

In response to public comments, this section clarifies why a detailed analysis of impacts to surface water features from the new live-fire component was not conducted.

A comprehensive analysis of ongoing training impacts on water resources across PCMS is provided in the 2015 EIS, to which this EA is tiered. Therefore, the detailed analysis in this EA focuses on whether reasonably foreseeable environmental effects for the action at hand are significant. For this EA, this action is the temporary impact area of the associated large-caliber live fire. To assess the total effect of the entire training event, the collective effects of both ongoing activities and these new components are evaluated in the "Analysis of the Proposed Action's Incremental Contribution" section of this EA.

The finding of no new effect is based on deliberate project siting, which is an intentionally used tool for impact avoidance. The specific location selected for the temporary impact area was chosen because it contains no mapped waterways or drainage features that drain into any Waters of the U.S.

Because the action was sited specifically to avoid these resources, the Army concluded that there would be no new direct or indirect effects to surface water features beyond those already analyzed in the 2015 EIS. Therefore, this resource issue was not carried forward for detailed analysis.

Wildlife

The wildlife community at PCMS is adapted to the shortgrass prairie environment. Common species include pronghorn, mule deer, coyotes, and a variety of birds, reptiles, and small mammals. The PCMS area also provides habitat for several federal and state-listed threatened, endangered, or other special status species.

This analysis is tiered from the 2015 EIS for Training and Operations at PCMS and the 2005 Range 9 EA. All activities will be conducted in accordance with the conservation measures outlined in the Fort Carson Integrated Natural Resources Management Plan (INRMP), which provides the overarching framework for protecting wildlife at PCMS. The general behavioral disturbance to wildlife from baseline activities that will also occur during this exercise—such as noise from vehicle maneuver, small arms fire, and helicopter support—is consistent with the ongoing training effects previously analyzed in the 2015 EIS or Training and Operations at PCMS.

Under the Proposed Action, impacts to wildlife are expected to be temporary and not significant. The primary impact will be short-term behavioral displacement of mobile wildlife due to impulsive noise generated by 155mm artillery firing, as well as general noise from vehicles and human presence. This type of disturbance is consistent with ongoing training activities analyzed in the referenced EIS and EA, and wildlife is expected to return to the area shortly after the event concludes.

The potential for direct mortality is negligible. As established in the previous analysis of soils and vegetation, the Proposed Action will not result in significant habitat loss. While there is a low but present potential for wildfire ignition from the munition's spotting charges, this risk will be managed through a multi-layered and robust approach to fire prevention. This includes strict adherence to the Integrated Wildland Fire Management Plan and leveraging established interagency agreements, supplemented by additional, dedicated firefighting resources posted to PCMS for the duration of the exercise. These measures effectively reduce the threat of fire to wildlife habitat.

Wildlife protection measures would follow the INRMP and include avoiding known sensitive wildlife locations such as raptor nests or pronghorn fawning areas, as well as maintaining appropriate buffers where needed. Because wildlife at PCMS is habituated to periodic training disturbance, impacts would be limited to temporary displacement. Because the impacts are limited to temporary behavioral displacement, do not involve significant habitat degradation, and will be conducted in full compliance with the protective measures of the INRMP, the Proposed Action is not expected to cause significant impacts to wildlife populations or their habitats.

Cultural Resources

PCMS has a rich history of human occupation spanning thousands of years, from prehistoric hunter-gatherers to historic-era ranching operations. Extensive archaeological surveys have been conducted across the installation, and numerous prehistoric and historic sites have been recorded. Many of these sites have been determined eligible for the National Register of Historic Places (NRHP) for their potential to yield important information about the past. All cultural resources are managed in accordance with the National Historic Preservation Act (NHPA) and the procedures outlined in the Fort Carson ICRMP.

In compliance with Section 106 of the National Historic Preservation Act (NHPA), 36 CFR 800 and the *Programmatic Agreement Among US Army Garrison Fort Carson, Colorado State Historic Preservation Officer, and the Advisory Council on Historic Preservation Regarding Military Training and Operational Support Activities at Pinon Canyon Maneuver Site (PCMS) (As amended)*, a formal Section 106 review was conducted to analyze the undertaking's effects on historic properties. This Environmental Assessment (EA) incorporates the findings of that separate analysis by reference. This analysis also tiers from the 2015 EIS for Training and Operations at PCMS, which describes the baseline of ongoing training activities (such as maneuver and small arms fire) that contribute to the existing cumulative effects on historic properties within PCMS.

The Area of Potential Effects (APE) was established for this undertaking, defined by SDZs and a 6,500-meter noise buffer. Within the APE, six historic properties eligible for the National Register were identified for analysis. The review of direct effects concluded that projectile impacts, primarily from 155mm artillery, could cause ground disturbance and shallow cratering, diminishing the integrity of sites located within the SDZs. A multicomponent historic homestead with a prehistoric component is located entirely within the Temporary Impact Area (TIA). A historic ranching complex is within a 155mm SDZ, while two separate prehistoric camp sites with Archaic components are located in areas where multiple SDZs overlap.

The review of effects concluded that projectile impacts, primarily from 155mm artillery, could cause ground disturbance and shallow cratering, diminishing the integrity of sites located within the SDZs. The Section 106 analysis found that while noise may be perceptible at some sites, it is not considered adverse because it is transitory and short-term. The analysis also found that the action contributes incrementally to adverse cumulative effects at several sites, particularly where multiple SDZs overlap, which degrades their long-term information potential. Due to the potential for physical impacts and the contribution to cumulative effects, the Section 106 analysis concluded that the undertaking would result in an Adverse Effect on historic properties.

Because avoidance of these adverse effects was not feasible due to mission requirements, the Army has resolved them through an alternative mitigation strategy. This strategy focuses on the development of two Multiple Property Documents (MPDs) and associated historic contexts, rather than site-specific data recovery. This approach was chosen because the MPDs will synthesize regional data from numerous other historic properties, many with higher integrity and greater information potential than

those being affected by this undertaking. One MPD will address Early Hispanic Settlement and Sheep Ranching, and a second will address the Middle Archaic Occupation of southeastern Colorado. The requirement to complete this mitigation is formally stipulated in a Memorandum of Agreement (MOA) signed by the Army and the Colorado State Historic Preservation Officer on March 20, 2026. The successful resolution of the adverse effect through this binding agreement ensures that the Proposed Action does not have a significant impact on the human environment.

Cultural resources would be protected from impacts from the maneuver training and other activities through adherence to the ICRMP and the Programmatic Agreement, which requires avoidance of all known archaeological sites and historic properties within the Range 9 SDZ. Maneuver lanes would be routed away from any identified cultural sites, and all personnel would receive cultural awareness briefings prior to training. If previously unidentified cultural materials are encountered during the exercise or during LRAM rehabilitation, work would stop immediately, and cultural resource staff would be notified in accordance with established procedures. Because no new ground disturbance is proposed, the potential for impacts to cultural resources is minimal.

Wildland Fire Risk

The use of live-fire munitions as part of the Proposed Action creates a potential for wildland fire ignitions. However, this risk has been analyzed and will be managed through a comprehensive, multi-layered approach involving proactive site preparation and strict operational controls, ensuring that the potential for significant impacts is low.

A key part of the risk management strategy is the implementation of proactive site management at PCMS, as guided by the Fort Carson Integrated Wildland Fire Management Plan (IWFMP). These activities include prescribed burns to reduce fuel loading in the training area and the maintenance and establishment of strategic firebreaks.

During the exercise itself, daily fire risk will be managed through a formal, structured process. The Fort Carson Fire Chief will generate daily fire and weather reports using real-time data from an on-site monitoring station, which informs a daily Fire Danger Rating. This rating dictates the mandatory restrictions placed on live-fire training. While the Operations Manager has the authority to grant exemptions to facilitate critical training, this process is strictly controlled. For instance, an "extreme" rating can only be downgraded to "very high," and if required aerial firefighting resources are unavailable during "extreme" conditions, all live-fire training is prohibited—a requirement that cannot be waived. To ensure a rapid response capability, dedicated firefighting resources, including additional crews and apparatus, will be on standby at the site for the duration of the event.

Furthermore, while the training is scheduled in May to meet mission requirements, analysis of historical data in the IWFMP shows this is a favorable time of year regarding fire risk. May is statistically one of the months with the lowest chance of experiencing "very high" or "extreme" fire danger conditions. This favorable seasonal timing, combined with the proactive fuel management and strict daily operational controls, supports the conclusion that the potential for a significant wildfire resulting from the Proposed Action is not significant.

Safety and Quality of Life

PCMS is a large, remote, military training installation located far from any permanent public residences or major population centers. Access to the training area will be restricted during the exercise.

Public Safety:

The primary measure to ensure public safety is the establishment of an SDZ for all weapons systems,

calculated in accordance with DA PAM 385-63. The SDZ is designed to contain all fired projectiles and associated debris. Access to the entire SDZ will be temporarily restricted to authorized personnel for the duration of the live-fire exercise. These procedures are standard for all live-fire training and are effective at eliminating risks to all personnel.

Fire management measures would be followed. The PCMS Fire Management Plan includes maintaining firefighting equipment on standby, conducting a fire risk assessment prior to training, and modifying or suspending training during periods of extreme fire danger.

Noise:

The primary source of noise will be impulsive noise from the firing of 155mm artillery. A formal analysis was conducted for this action, based on the methodology from the Fort Carson Installation Compatible Use Zone Study (2018). A noise analysis completed in the Cultural Resources Section 106 review conservatively modeled the noise effects as occurring within a 6,500-foot buffer from the centroid of the firing points. The analysis indicated that the noise contour could extend slightly beyond the northern boundary of PCMS into an area with no residences or other sensitive human noise receptors.

The 2018 Noise Study shows that noise contours from existing, ongoing large-caliber training at PCMS already extend into an uninhabited area just to the east. To date, these existing operations have not generated public noise complaints. The noise generated by this single, short-duration training event is consistent with these existing conditions and does not introduce a new type or level of noise impact to any off-post sensitive receptor.

To ensure the public is informed of training activities, the Fort Carson Public Affairs Office (PAO) issues press releases and other notifications to surrounding communities. Additionally, the installation maintains a noise complaint hotline for the public to report any concerns. Therefore, because the limited off-post noise is confined to an unpopulated area and is consistent with existing, approved training operations, the noise impacts of the Proposed Action are not considered significant.

Air Quality:

Impacts on air quality will be temporary and minor. The primary sources of emissions will be fugitive dust (PM10) generated by vehicles moving over unpaved surfaces and exhaust from vehicle engines. The low-yield spotting charges on the munitions will produce a minimal amount of particulate matter upon detonation. The formal analysis concluded that dust and atmospheric effects would be short-term and localized. These emissions fall well within the scope of activities analyzed in the 2015 EIS, which found that training operations at PCMS conform to the State Implementation Plan.

With standard safety protocols in place, and with the formal analysis concluding that all noise impacts will be contained within the installation and air quality effects will be temporary and localized, the Proposed Action is not expected to cause significant impacts to safety or quality of life.

Analysis of the Proposed Action's Incremental Contribution

The purpose of this analysis is to determine if the incremental impacts of the Proposed Action, which are temporary and minor, would contribute significantly to the cumulative picture when added to other past, present, and reasonably foreseeable future training actions at PCMS.

- **Soil and Vegetation Resources:** The ongoing training at PCMS results in cumulative impacts from vehicle maneuver. The Proposed Action contributes a negligible increment to this total effect. While the use of spotting charges may cause shallow cratering and localized scorching of vegetation, these minor disturbances are consistent with training effects, fall within the scope of

impacts managed by the LRAM/ITAM program, and do not contribute significantly to cumulative effects.

- **Wildlife:** The cumulative effect on wildlife at PCMS is primarily behavioral displacement due to noise from training. The Proposed Action adds a minor, temporary increment of impulsive noise from 155mm artillery. It does not permanently remove habitat, and the low risk of wildfire is managed. This minor contribution does not significantly add to the cumulative effects on wildlife populations.
- **Cultural Resources:** The Section 106 analysis for this undertaking found that the Proposed Action does contribute to adverse cumulative effects. At several historic properties, particularly those within overlapping Surface Danger Zones, the action adds incrementally to an existing pattern of disturbance that, over time, diminishes site integrity. While these effects are considered adverse under the National Historic Preservation Act (NHPA), they will be resolved through a robust alternative mitigation strategy, ensuring the undertaking does not result in a significant impact on the human environment under NEPA. The Army signed an MOA with the Colorado SHPO on March 20, 2026, to illustrate its commitment to executing this mitigation, which involves the development of two MPDs to address regional data gaps. In accordance with DoD and Army NEPA implementing procedures, an EIS should not be prepared when environmental impacts can be mitigated through other statutory processes such as the National Historic Preservation Act (NHPA).
- **Safety, Noise, and Air Quality:** The Proposed Action contributes a negligible increment to the overall noise and emissions profile of PCMS. The formal noise analysis concluded that while noise contours may extend slightly beyond the installation's northern boundary, they will only affect an unpopulated area where no sensitive human receptors are present. This minor off-post effect is consistent with existing noise from ongoing training and does not contribute to a cumulative noise impact on any public area. Air quality impacts are localized and temporary. When the negligible effects of the Proposed Action are added to the impacts of other past, present, and reasonably foreseeable future actions, the total cumulative effect on noise and air quality remains not significant.

The environmental effects of the Proposed Action are temporary, localized, and not individually significant. When added to the effects of other past, present, and reasonably foreseeable future training actions at PCMS, the incremental contribution of this single, brigade-level exercise is negligible. Therefore, the Proposed Action is not expected to result in significant cumulative effects on any resource.

ENVIRONMENTAL CONSEQUENCES OF THE NO ACTION ALTERNATIVE

Under the No Action Alternative, the proposed CALFEX would not be authorized, and no munitions would be fired. The unit would, however, still conduct the maneuver portions of the exercise at PCMS. Therefore, the baseline for comparison is a maneuver-only training event. The environmental consequences are as follows:

Impacts from the off-road movement of Strykers and other military vehicles—including soil compaction, rutting, and the crushing of vegetation—would still occur. These impacts are consistent with those analyzed in the 2015 EIS for Training and Operations at PCMS and the 2005 Range 9 EA. This alternative would only avoid the additional, minor, and localized surface impacts resulting from the impact of the inert training projectiles or those with small spotting charges.

The No Action Alternative would result in nearly identical environmental consequences to the Proposed Action with regard to maneuver-related activities. It would only avoid the temporary and minor impacts associated with the firing of inert munitions (e.g., localized soil indentations and impulse noise). Crucially, the No Action Alternative would not meet the purpose and need of the Proposed Action, as it would prevent the unit from achieving its mandatory live-fire certification, thereby risking force readiness.

ENVIRONMENTAL ASSESSMENT CERTIFICATION:

I certify, as the responsible official, that the resulting EA represents Fort Carson's good-faith effort to fulfill NEPA's requirements within the Congressional timeline; that such effort is substantially complete; that, in Fort Carson's expert opinion, it has thoroughly considered the factors mandated by NEPA; and that, in Fort Carson's judgment, the analysis contained therein is adequate to inform and reasonably explain my final decision regarding the proposed federal action.

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Erik C. Oksenvaag
Colonel, U.S. Army
Garrison Commander

Date

**FINDING OF NO SIGNIFICANT IMPACT
for the Ivy Mass 2026 Training Exercise
at Pinon Canyon Maneuver Site, Fort Carson, CO**

1. INTRODUCTION

In accordance with the National Environmental Policy Act (NEPA) of 1969 and the Department of Defense (DoD) and U.S. Army NEPA implementing procedures, the U.S. Army has prepared an Environmental Assessment (EA) for the establishment of a Temporary Impact Area (TIA) to support the Ivy Mass combined arms live-fire exercise (CALFEX) at Piñon Canyon Maneuver Site (PCMS). This Finding of No Significant Impact (FONSI) is based on the analysis presented in that EA, which concludes that the Proposed Action will not have a significant impact on the human environment.

2. DESCRIPTION OF THE PROPOSED ACTION AND NO ACTION ALTERNATIVE

Proposed Action: The U.S. Army proposes to establish a TIA to support a single, month-long CALFEX at PCMS. The purpose is to allow a brigade to certify on critical warfighting tasks driven by new digital command and control technology. The Proposed Action includes maneuver, aerial support, the construction of temporary trenches, and the live fire of munitions from ground-based weapons systems including 155mm artillery, 7.62mm, and .50 caliber ammunition. The analysis conservatively assumes the use of training munitions with low-yield spotting charges (0.5 lbs of TNT). The TIA will be closed and the area restored upon completion of the event.

No Action Alternative: Under the No Action Alternative, the TIA would not be established and the large-caliber (155mm) portion of the live-fire would not occur. The unit would still conduct maneuvers and all previously approved live-fire training at PCMS, including small arms up to .50 caliber. This alternative does not meet the purpose and need for the action because the inability to integrate live artillery fire would prevent the unit from validating its new digital command and control systems, failing to meet certification requirements and risking mission readiness.

National Training Center (NTC). As detailed in the Final EA, the NTC alternative was eliminated from detailed study because it is doctrinally inappropriate for this specific, intermediate-level certification event, which is a prerequisite for a subsequent NTC rotation.

3. SUMMARY OF ENVIRONMENTAL ANALYSIS

The EA analyzed the potential environmental impacts of the Proposed Action and found the following:

Soil and Vegetation Resources: Impacts are temporary and not significant. Effects include minor soil compaction and vegetation trampling from vehicles, and shallow cratering and potential scorching from munitions with spotting charges. The wildfire risk will be managed with a multi-layered and robust approach to fire prevention. This includes strict adherence to the Integrated Wildland Fire Management Plan and leveraging established interagency agreements, supplemented by additional, dedicated firefighting resources posted to PCMS for the duration of the exercise. All disturbed areas will be restored by the LRAM program.

Wildlife: Impacts are temporary and not significant. The primary impact is short-term displacement of wildlife due to noise from large-caliber live fire. No significant habitat

degradation will occur, and all activities will comply with the Integrated Natural Resources Management Plan (INRMP).

Cultural Resources: The formal Section 106 consultation concluded that the undertaking will result in an adverse effect to historic properties due to direct physical impacts and cumulative effects. This adverse effect will be resolved through an alternative mitigation strategy, as stipulated through the conclusion of the Section 106 process and the Memorandum of Agreement (MOA) signed by the Army and The Colorado State Historic Preservation Officer (SHPO) on March 20, 2026.

Wildland Fire Risk: The potential for significant impacts from wildfire is low. This finding is based on a multi-layered management approach detailed in the EA, which includes proactive site preparation, strict daily operational controls guided by a formal Fire Danger Rating System, and the stationing of dedicated firefighting resources on-site for the duration of the event.

Safety and Quality of Life: Impacts are not significant. Standard safety protocols, including the establishment of a Surface Danger Zone (SDZ), will protect public safety. It is estimated that while noise may extend slightly beyond the PCMS boundary, it will not affect any public residences or sensitive receptors. Air quality effects will be temporary and localized.

4. MITIGATION MEASURES

The finding of no significant impact is based on the formal resolution of adverse effects identified during the Section 106 consultation process under the National Historic Preservation Act (NHPA). The following mitigation is required to resolve the undertaking's adverse effects on historic properties as agreed to in the March 20, 2026, MOA signed by the Army and the Colorado SHPO, thereby ensuring the action does not have a significant impact on the human environment. The Army will resolve the adverse effects of the undertaking by executing an alternative mitigation strategy. This strategy, outlined in the Section 106 undertaking review, focuses on the development of two Multiple Property Documents (MPDs) and associated historic contexts to address regional data gaps related to Early Hispanic Settlement and Middle Archaic Occupation.

5. FINDING

Based on the analysis contained in the EA, which has been tiered from existing environmental documents, and with the implementation of the mitigation measures described above, the U.S. Army concludes that the Proposed Action will not have a significant impact on the quality of the human or natural environment. Therefore, the preparation of an Environmental Impact Statement (EIS) is not required.

6. DECISION

I have carefully reviewed the Environmental Assessment and the factors supporting this Finding of No Significant Impact.

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Erik C. Oksenvaag
Colonel, U.S. Army
Garrison Commander

Date